

COMMON GROUNDS

Siblings,
Individuals,
and Friends



Common Grounds

Abstract

This essay reflects on the progression of a *process-based co-design series of workshops*. The target of this project is to collect a series of artistic inputs delivered primarily individually, to slowly shift towards a bond contribution of building a more or less fictional narrative. The narrative is inspired by the children's passions and ambitions, but it also reflects an idea of the dynamics between these two siblings in cause.

Ultimately, the narrative built should immerse the siblings in understanding each other through creative means. This text develops on the use of relevant research references to delimitate between adopted paradigms and contradicting theories. The direction and roots of the project titled *Common Grounds* lie in sensitive and flexible approaches to the topic's matter. Child-centeredness and Deleuzoguattarian 'smooth spaces' allocate a proper definition of the process. The title illustrates the workshops' scope, while also projecting a metaphor for the self-image mirroring as an outcome.

This Co-Design project can be situated on the sixth level on Hart's ladder of children's participation.⁽ⁱⁱ⁾ It is adult-initiated, while most design decisions are taken together with children's judgement, or based on their direct reactions. In more general instances, the father of the two children collaborating within Common Grounds, influences the course of the design process, claiming a collaborative role.

^[1]Hart, R. A. (1979). *Children's Participation from Tokenism to Citizenship*, New York, UNICEF, p. 4

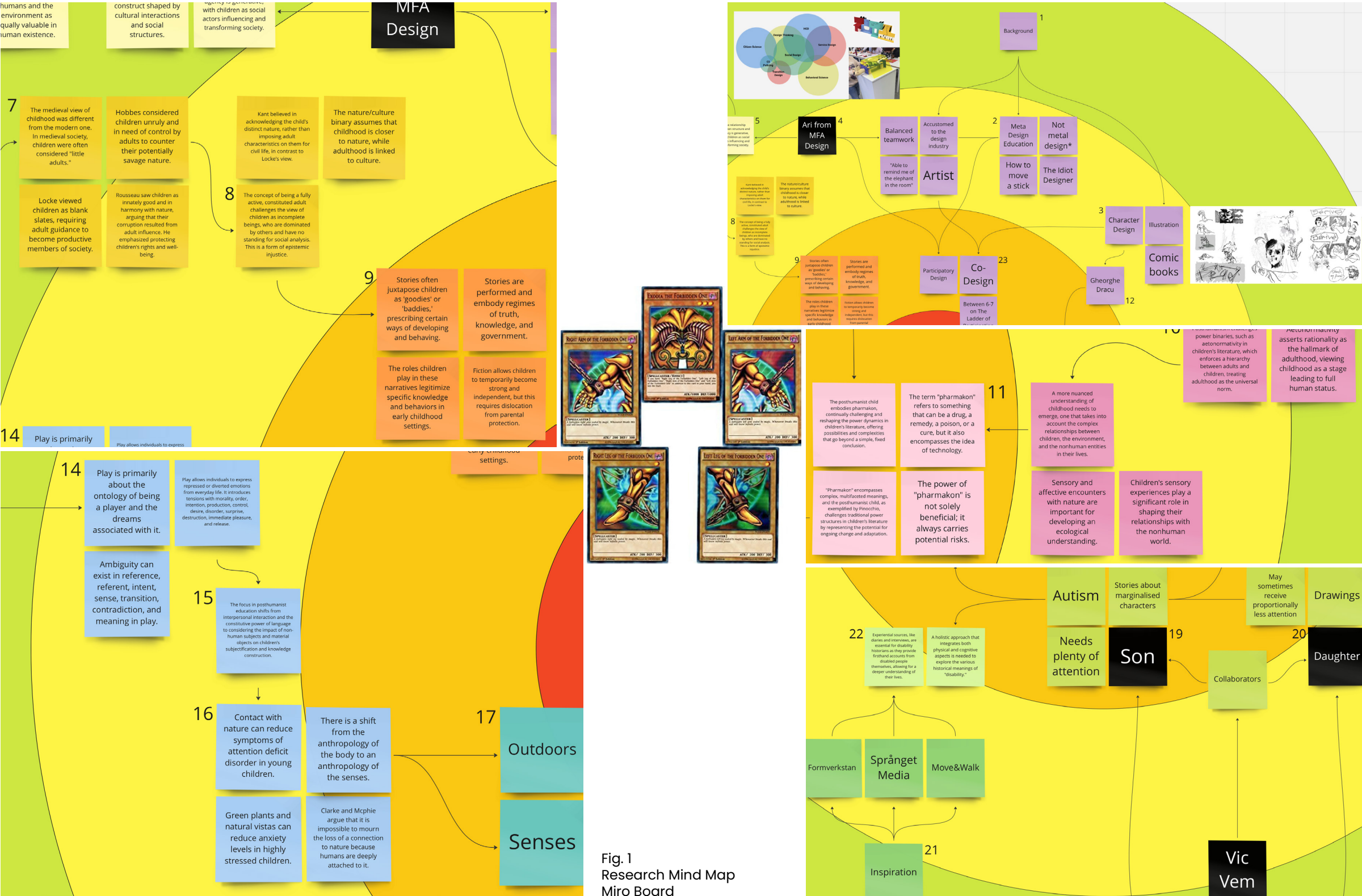


Fig. 1
Research Mind Map
Miro Board

Framing

Throughout the Literary Review subchapters you can read about the *philosophical anchor* that my collaborator Ari Pugu and I have explored in the iteration phase of this co-design project. Ari and I dive into topics as posthumanism, aetonormativity, childism, and ableism, with the goal of learning how to consolidate an *ethical design attitude*.

Posthumanism and disability have been the meeting grounds of our research until direct activation of our learnings in a series of workshops. Starting off with anchoring in philosophy and quantitative research studies on the matter we have gained, I believe, a solid momentum for application. Our methodologies suggest *flexibility* and *improvisation*. Posthumanism in particular is a good lens for widely unfolding human-centeredness and unbalanced power dynamics within society, especially at the expense of people with disabilities. Posthumanism questions the idea of ableist hegemony. Another offspring notion of posthumanism is aetonormativity, a concept dedicated to the power dynamics projected between children and adults. In both cases we reflect upon inequality and human condition. What can designers learn from our contribution?

Both aetonormativity and ableism are systematically reinforcing the idea that *some people are less people than others*, to put it this way. Be it suggesting that a child does not have the capacities to channel agency with the same thoughtfulness and skillfulness that the grown-up status quo insinuates; or suggesting that a neurodivergent person’s agency lacks the affirmation and determination of a neurotypical person; both systems of oppression are criticized under posthumanism’s umbrella for their intersecting dehumanizing philosophies. I thought that dwelling under a philosophy that directly criticizes both major forms of oppression that oppose the means of this project, Ari and I would have the opportunity to adopt an appropriate theoretical framework instead investing valuable time from the iteration phase into creating a framework from scratch. This allowed us to lean against a common way of judging decisions before taking them. It gave us a platform for discussion, where both of us were just as newly acquainted to posthumanism, while at the same time, we both found it accessible and fitting in relation to our own approach in regard to ableism and aetonormativity. It played its role as a good start for learning more on the matter, but also to make sure we think in sync.

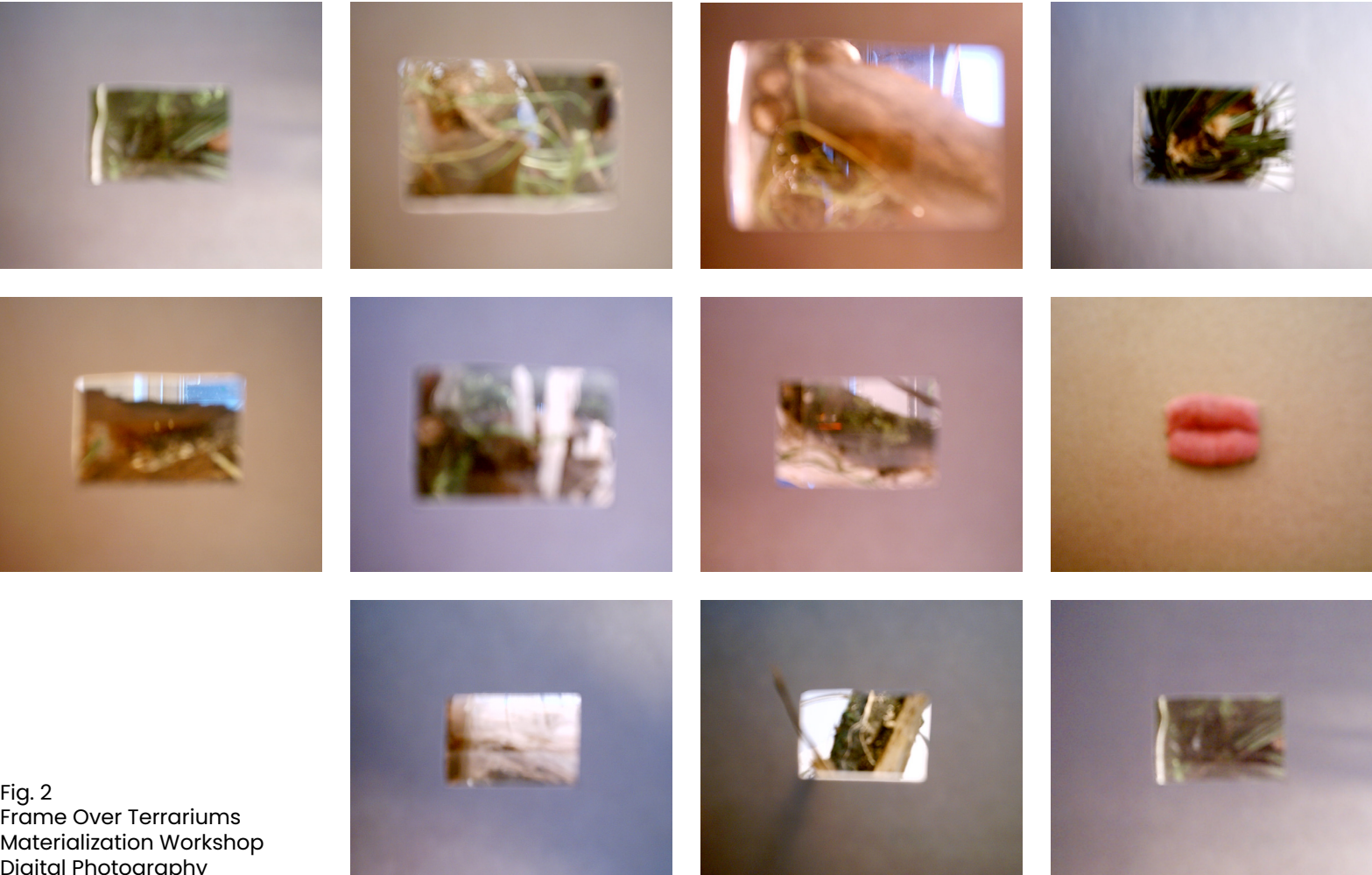


Fig. 2
Frame Over Terrariums
Materialization Workshop
Digital Photography

Posthumanism as Philosophical Anchor

Posthumanism, the critical discourse that seeks to understand and dismantle the privileged status of the humanist subject, and the correlational concept of the ‘posthuman’ as the subject that exists beyond the boundaries that broadly define humanity have been the pillars of the philosophy by which Ari Pugu and I have sheltered our drive throughout the earliest stages of the project conception.^[2]

We felt the need to have some sort of anchor in order to release the other elements of the project (materialization, methods, stakeholders, etc.) into prompt open-endedness. To put it as such, we adopt a ‘papanekian’ strategy, by making space for a design attitude prior to designing. The design attitude in cause being one of centering the child experience and child perspective for the matter of ethical engagement of our skills and practices. The concern of championing heterogeneity instead of ‘reproducing... the sacred image of the Same’, as Haraway puts it, overshadows the perspectives that we try to project in the incipient phases onto our assumed direction of research regarding children’s literature and especially the matter of aetonormativity.^[3]

Aetonormativity extends over social conditions, in real as well as in fictive world, in which adults have a status of superiority above children at all times, the power hierarchy being non-negotiable and inevitably self-reproducing.^[4] Therefore, the project proposal must be rooted in an idea (or more correlating ideas) of the stakeholder.

If posthumanism is the platform for discussion, the pharmakon is the actor. In the next subsection you can read about the effects of building narratives based on adult-centered morals, and how a shift to child-centeredness can speak deeply to a child audience. My intention with adopting the pharmakon concept is to support genuinity in our collaboration, but also to entertain the children, so they feel motivated to build on top of each other’s involvement. The children have to see themselves in the story in the details of the story. It is their story.

^[2]Flanagan, V. (2018). “Posthumanism: Rethinking ‘the Human’ in Modern Children’s Literature. The Edinburgh Companion to Children’s Literature., edited by Cl  mentine Beauvais and Maria Nikolajeva, Edinburgh University Press

^[3]Haraway, D. (2004). “The Promises of Monsters: A Regenerative Politics for Inappropriate/d Others.” The Haraway Reader, Routledge, pp. 63–124

^[4]Nikolajeva, M. (2009). Power, Voice and Subjectivity in Literature for Young Readers. Routledge

Child Pharmakon vs. Child-Written Pharmakon

The subject in focus is the ‘posthumanist child’, who remains, as Burton suggests, ‘hidden under a veritable maelstrom of analytical demands’.^[5] Haraway^[3] uses an optical metaphor to address an approach that maps the effects of difference. She refers to ‘diffraction’ as a mapping of interference, not of reflection, or reproduction.

The notion of diffraction as an oppositional strategy towards the hierarchical interferences of aetonormative deconstructivism, finds its reformulation in Plato’s ‘pharmakon’, which is, in Borton’s words, ‘not only a drug, a remedy, a poison, a cure, but also a tekhn  , [and/or] an artifice’.^[6] Burton relates the status of pharmakon to Collodi’s Pinocchio, a character that under aetonormativistic prospects is charged as a cure, one that is, under Barad’s words, sanitized and also sanitizing a view of childhood.^[5]

Pinocchio’s learnings unfortunately do not center the child perspective genuinely, but rather a perspective projected through a lens that carries *aetonormative morals*. As Burton concludes, ‘[an] apparatus of children’s literature, which adults continually try to reduce to its didactic cure’.^[5] Therefore, a considerable attempt at exploring and delivering a consistent child-centered narrative would be to engage children to write literature themselves, without promoting a deduction for ‘childness’. The pharmakon actor can be the threshold bender itself, one that allows the writer to transpass back and forth between the ‘reality of fiction’ and the ‘fiction of reality’. But in order to do so properly, the pharmakon must be formulated by the writers themselves. The iminance of hijacking the narrative’s intentions by planting an actor of aetonormativity such as Pinocchio is dismantled if the writer introduces a pharmakon based on their own set of morals.

The *Child-Written Pharmakon* concept became an essential tool for tightening the collaboration. On a practical level, the child-written pharmakon brings enough resilience simply by being familiar, but also for the way it realtes to its authors.

^[5]Burton, L. (2019). The Posthumanist Child: Pharmakon and Collodi’s Pinocchio. Oxford Literary Review, 41(2), 202–218. <https://doi.org/10.3366/olr.2019.0279>

^[6]Barad, K. (2007), Meeting the Universe Halfway: Quantum Physics and the Entanglement of Matter and Meaning. Duke University Press

The child-written pharmakon is the means of our collaboration, the mission, the tekhne, the artifice, the question, and the answer. It is something to mold based on our own identities. I believe that seeing a piece of ourselves out there gives us the comfort and curiosity to reach towards whatever it is, and consequently learn something new. Without a *mirror* in a new world, we have no clue where to start from and what to do. We always start exactly from where we already are. Why would this not apply to children as well? Why not let them write their own stories? :)



Fig. 3
Workshop Materials

Intra-Active Space

In the previous paragraphs we formed a couple of pillar notions regarding posthumanism and the posthuman child. These notions help us criticize the hegemony of aetonnormativity and its means of epistemic injustice embedded in children’s literature. Another branch of this critique can be expanded through challenging the anthropocentric notion of human superiority. This can be enunciated through horizontal readings of the documentation collected throughout conversations and workshops with the stakeholders.^[7]

To be more precise, the concept of ‘horizontal’ refers to a ‘flattened’ and non-hierarchical view on children’s relationships with other humans and the ‘more-than-human world’. As Lenz Taguchi^[8] argues, the subject together with ‘things’, ‘emerge through, and as a part of their entangled intra-actions with everything else.’ If neither humans nor things pre-exist their interactions with the world,^[6] then we must be conscious of the interplay between the creative environment and its intrinsic affect on progression and production. The levels of acquaintanceship and freedom assigned to a space not only interfere with the process, but might as well be used as a container of the narrative, and so develop in tandem with the story and the creators of the story in question. This implies general growth and change applied to participants, methodology, items, but also to the space itself.

^[7]Skolverket. (2012). Uppföljning, utvärdering och utveckling i förskolan: pedagogisk dokumentation. [Follow-up, evaluation and development in preschool: Pedagogical documentation]. Stockholm: Skolverket

^[8]Lenz Taguchi, H. (2010). Going beyond the theory/practice divide in early childhood education: Introducing an intra-active pedagogy. Abingdon: Routledge

Autonomy, Agency, and Voice

Starting from Curran’s affirmation, ‘*studies of disabled children’s impairments or developments are not studies of their childhood*’,^[9] I adopt a design attitude towards this project that suggests sensitivity and allows a genuine dive into the creative endeavors of two siblings on an individual level; at the same time, the iteration of the process-based project I propose, demands acquaintanceship to the dynamics of the relationship between these two siblings. I follow a path of seeing the child before the diagnosis even within a case study.

Within early methods of Participatory Design, ableist conceptualizations of ‘participation’ framed the autonomous child’s voice as a literal voice or observable social competencies.^[10] This attitude promulgated enacting ‘voice’ in non-normative ways as having nothing to say.^[11] Of course, nowadays we can find several studies that contradict the primordial ways of Participatory Design, which I would like to inspire my process through ethics that center the child’s experience.^[12;13] I document the child experience in form of dialogue, artifacts created during workshops, father’s impressions, and drawings. My intention is to have a round approach regarding the documentation in order to capture a representative and balanced depiction of the child’s experience throughout this series of workshops.

Together with Nahuel (10 years old, diagnosed with autism) and Ayelen (5 years old, undiagnosed), I create a narrative line that fosters a collection of their short stories and drawings. One commonly asked question would be: ‘Who tells the over-arching story?’, or ‘Who’s ‘voice’ is it?’, That brings me to the ethnographic ethics of my implication. ‘Tagging along with each other’,^[14] or ‘taking ourselves along’,^[15] better fence the means of my perspective. The compelling nature of subjectivity and experience allocates light-heartedness, flexibility, and fluidity to the efforts of *pursuing a result celebrated by the process*.

Following the philosophy behind Deleuzoguattarian ‘smooth spaces’, I frame the project’s balance between facilitation and participation as an assemblage, instead of a hierarchical reading of singulars.^[16] Our collaboration lies within the parameters of a co-design practice independent of normative and non-normative biopolitical governance, discarding the latter-mentioned discipline as reductive and counter-productive.^[17] The Deleuzoguattarian concept of ‘smooth spaces’ dwells instances of the case study allocated to ‘affectedness’. Through affectedness, the designer does not simply encompass a sterile summary of the study, but realizes ways to join the design process with the group, not only as facilitator, but as participant as well.

^[9]Curran, T. (2013). “Disabled Children’s Childhood Studies: alternative Relations and Forms of authority.” In Disabled Children’s Childhood Studies: Critical Approaches in a Global Context, edited by Tillie Curran and Katherine Runswick-Cole, 121–135. New york: Palgrave Macmillan

^[10]Davis, J., N. Watson, and S. Cunningham-burley. (2008). “Disabled Children, ethnography and Unspoken”

^[11]Beresford, byrony. (1997). Personal accounts: Involving Disabled Children in Research. Norwich: Social Policy Research Unit

^[12]Curran, Tillie, and Katherine Runswick-Cole. (2013). Disabled Children’s Childhood Studies: Critical Approaches in a Global Context. New york: Palgrave Macmillan

^[13]Curran, Tillie, and Katherine Runswick-Cole. (2014). “Disabled Children’s Childhood Studies: a Distinct approach?” Disability & Society 29 (10): 1617–1630. doi:10.1080/09687599.2014.966187

^[14]Roets, G., and M. Goedgeluck. (2007). “Daisies on the Road: Tracing the Political Potential of our Postmodernist, Feminist approach to life Story Research.” Qualitative Inquiry 13 (1): 85–112. doi:10.1177/1077800406295624

^[15]Schwandt, Thomas a. (2004). “Hermeneutics: a Poetics of Inquiry Versus a Methodology for Research.” In Educational Research: Difference and Diversity, edited by Heather Piper and Iain Stronach, 31–44. aldershot: ashgate Publishing

^[16]Deleuze, Gilles, and Félix Guattari. (1987). A Thousand Plateaus: Capitalism and Schizophrenia. Minneapolis, MN: University of Minnesota Press

^[17]Youdell, Deborah, and Felicity armstrong. (2011). “a Politics beyond Subjects: The affective Choreographies and Smooth Spaces of Schooling.” Emotion, Space and Society 4 (3): 144–150. doi:10.1016/j.emospa.2011.01.002



Co-Creating Stories

This project is based in co-design methodology and revolves around the purpose of making stories from scratch together with children with autism and their siblings. For the ease of exploration and creation, the traditional practice of writing stories is separated into three crucial factors (characters, world-building, and timeline) and translated into less conventional, more playful, and flexible methods. The exhibits are examples of artefacts that have been made for/ with/ by two siblings.

Above is a paragraph that encompasses a brief description of the project mid-way through the process. I expose this in order to support transparency of formation. As written above, the project has a strong emphasis on *autism*. A good part of this case study centers Nahuel’s diagnosis. The case study is held in a collaborative setup together with the stakeholders. It is rather qualitative research than quantitative, because I only work together with one family and one other designer. If the project benefited of a large number of participants, it could have been an opportunity to develop it as a qualitative research project. The larger number would play a generous role in terms of concluding precise observations on the diagnosis matter. Having that sort of expectation from the reader in mind, I stress the fact that this case study is not about autism more than it is about the group identity in *relation* to autism, childhood, siblinghood, story-telling, and co-designing. Autism in children is an evidently crucial element of this project, submitting genuine care and attention to empowering and enabling Nahuel. At the same time, the topic of autism in children does not cast shade onto any of those enumerated earlier.

Figs. 4, 5, and 6
Reversed Cinema
Installation
Cheesecloth Fabric



Fig. 7
Workshop Materials
Mixed Media

Background
Fig. 8
Reversed Cinema
Installation
Cheesecloth

Fig. 9
Fimo Figurines

Description of Methods

Tsao’s and McCabe’s Protocol

Tsao and McCabe^[18] have provided a protocol for the means of supporting proper interactions between a child with autism and a typically developing sibling. This sibling play intervention is grounded in observing the likes of the focal child (diagnosed child) and inviting the sibling to play similarly. The protocol inclines its means towards the focus child, placing the sibling in an assistive role.

The protocol, as Tsao and McCabe have formulated it, allows participants other than the focus child to bring quite little of their personality to the foreground. I believe it can be used within such a case study if the protocol is also mirrored at times. I believe that switching roles and the focus from one sibling to the other may generate more opportunities for meeting in the middle, in comparison to pursuing to meet the needs of mostly the diagnosed sibling.

Of course, I see the values and benefits behind the protocol in the suggested format. Tsao and McCabe rather concentrate on emotional regulation and strictly focused bonding sessions. Tsao and McCabe distribute the means of the process into bridging the focus child under the circumstances of the diagnosed child’s social comfort. The protocol is also generally more easily applied if the sibling is older than the focus child.

Reality-Based and Imaginary-Based Creativity

Studies have shown that children with autism may have difficulties with both *reality-based and imaginary-based creativity*.^[19;20] Concluding from the first two workshops I had with Nahuel and Ayelen, and the previous research, I speculate that a normative discipline of methods would be inefficient for properly emphasizing the creativity of the two children. Flexibility in approach and use of stimuli-based elements are effective for motivating the children to participate.^[21] Another asset for keeping them engaged is integrating their already mentioned creations into the contents of following workshops.

Therefore, I iterated a workshop that includes a tent-inspired cylindric cloth installation, accompanied by projections of the characters they have created. They would be invited into the *Reversed Cinema* (pages 10 and 11) and asked to make up the dialogues between characters on the spot. This would teach me directly what levels of engagement and collaboration the children are willing to invest at once. I would see their immediate reactions to each other and collect valuable information about their dynamics for designing one last method-based workshop that would hopefully benefit of a balanced interaction that satisfy both children as a team.

The Reversed Cinema workshop concept comes in need of a deconstructed version. This deconstructed version is a display of introductions to each pillar element of the Reversed Cinema. First of all, the room would be lit. The story-line’s visual contents would be available to the children to look through and edit. The children’s father and I would tell the story together as I will have written it by that time. Vic both translates and interprets. And, of course, the Reversed Cinema would be displayed in the room, not as a center piece, but simply for the self-initiated acquaintance coming from the children. This way the children would develop a smooth connection with this ‘more-than-human world’.

Carol Gray’s Social Stories

In 1991 Carol Gray created a method based on using short descriptions of particular situations, events, or activities, which include specific information about what to expect in that situation and why, to allow children with autism an objective look at social situations that may take place in their lives, and explore the possibilities of facing those situations without the stakes implied by physically being part of that certain event. This method also advantages the stakeholder by developing their self-care skills, helping them understand how to cope with changes in routine and unexpected or distressing events, and developing their self-esteem.

To write a social story one must picture a purpose for the story, gather information regarding the situation, and tailor the text in an accessible manner. I take inspiration from the clear-cut structure of Gray’s method^[22] and try to integrate elements of it into my practice, such as embedding the narrative of the story that the children write with my help, into premisses of the relationship between the two siblings. The children are familiar with the characters they have created, and those characters are depicted and presented to the two siblings as meeting each other. The characters carry some of the personality traits of those who have created them, such traits as values and convictions. Therefore an acquaintanceship of those may project a creative acquaintanceship of the children.

Gray also developed a method with similar intentions and stakeholders that makes use of visual representations in the sequential format of a comic strip.^[23] ‘*Comic Strip Conversations*’ lead me to believe that my prior speculation regarding bringing visual stimuli and depictive imagery of the environments and characters created by the children advantages the children in the matter of immersion. I try to integrate both methods of telling a story and inviting to take part in it, not only to drive it to completion but rather to emphasize the experience-based narration process.

Fun, Flow, and Narrative

I appeal to Csikszentmihalyi’s concept of ‘flow’, just as Luc Steels, who observes that such focussed activity can be seen in children at play.^[24] For an activity to be fun, employing flow, it has to be challenging and must allow a steady progression. A sense of control and opportunities provided by the environment are crucial for effectiveness. Providing children the option to shift from one role to another, (audience, actor, scriptwriter, and editor) coagulates their understanding of the narrative we build together.^[22] I consider that a role-shifting strategy deeply embeds the notion of collaboration in the child’s experience.

If, ‘narrative is fundamental to understanding ourselves and our relationship to the social environment’,^[26] then providing a platform that involves both the real and the imaginary relationships these children create or are already part of, would ultimately morph the shared space into ‘smooth space’.

^[18]Tsao, L., & McCabe, H. (2010). Why won’t he play with me? Facilitating sibling interactions. *Young Exceptional Children*, 13, 24–35

^[19]Frith, U. (1972) Cognitive mechanisms in autism: Experiments with color and tone sequence production. *Journal of Autism and Childhood Schizophrenia*, 2, 160-173

^[20]Scott, F., & Baron-Cohen, S. (1996). Imagining real and unreal things: Evidence of a dissociation in autism. *Journal of Cognitive Neuroscience*, 8, 400-411

^[21]Tegano, D. W., & Moran, J. D. (1989). Developmental study of the effect of dimensionality and presentation mode on original thinking of children. *Perceptual and Motor Skills*, 68, 1275-

^[22]Gray, C. (2015) *The new Social Story book: 15th Anniversary Edition*. Future Horizons Firm

^[23]Gray, C. (1994) *Comic strip conversations: illustrated interactions with students with autism and related disorders*

^[24]Steels, L. (2004). The architecture of flow. In: Tokoro, M., Steels, L. (eds.) *A Learning Zone of One’s Own*. IOS press, Lille

^[25]Marshall, P., Rogers, Y., Scaife, M. (2002). Puppet: a virtual environment for children to act and direct interactive narratives. In: *Proceedings of the Second Workshop on Narrative and Interactive Learning Environments*

^[26]Davis, M., Dautenhahn, K., Nehaniv, C., Powell, S.D. (2004). Towards an interactive system facilitating therapeutic narrative elicitation in autism. In: *3rd International Conference on Narrative and Interactive Learning Environments*, Edinburgh

Environment-Based Character-Building

Skatemark Monday 23rd October

FÖRKÄRA
SEN.

DET KOMMER LITE.

ETT
HUNDERS
TOLV!

JAMHÄR!

BARA TUA?

ÄR DET
HÄR?

"NO YOU HAVE
EVERYTHING!"

SKANNA
ENTLIGEN
...NÄR FRÅGA...

BARA JORBA
CINSPÉ CENTRIMETRI...
...CA IN ROMANIA DA.

JAGGA SA NYCKET!
JAG BETALADE TACK SÅ BRA!

JAG SÅ VISA
HILIN

VI SKA
HEMMA
TUA
VECKOR

GN!

10. morning...

Omar at Skatteverket

- No, she doesn't know. She said she doesn't know, now, how else could I know if she knows or she...

...
- Yes, yes. No worries. No problem.
Look, I'm in the building already, and...

...
- I love you too. Kisses.

- Ah, man... I'm sweating...

The Elevator Elevates

The statue continues.

- Hedonic disobedience must, of course, be incipiently approached through hedonic dissonance, which is often romanticized. 'Pure impiousness', if I may.

The elevator opens and a young man steps out of it. He locks his pupils on the marble sculpture in front of him.

- You see, my friend, these plaster eyes of mine shyly symbolize the spacial hegemony over my senses. It is a metaphor, indeed. My eyes, my skin, my hair, and even my garments are one and the same. Therefore, as I was elucidating previously, I am NOT seeing, nor touching, but both in tandem. D'you follow..? The boy in front of us finds joy and entertainment in merely a few separated senses, and while exposing himself to beauty - poor guy - his means of detaching from the visual realm are numbered and shallow. What a nightmare on his behalf...

The elevator elevates.

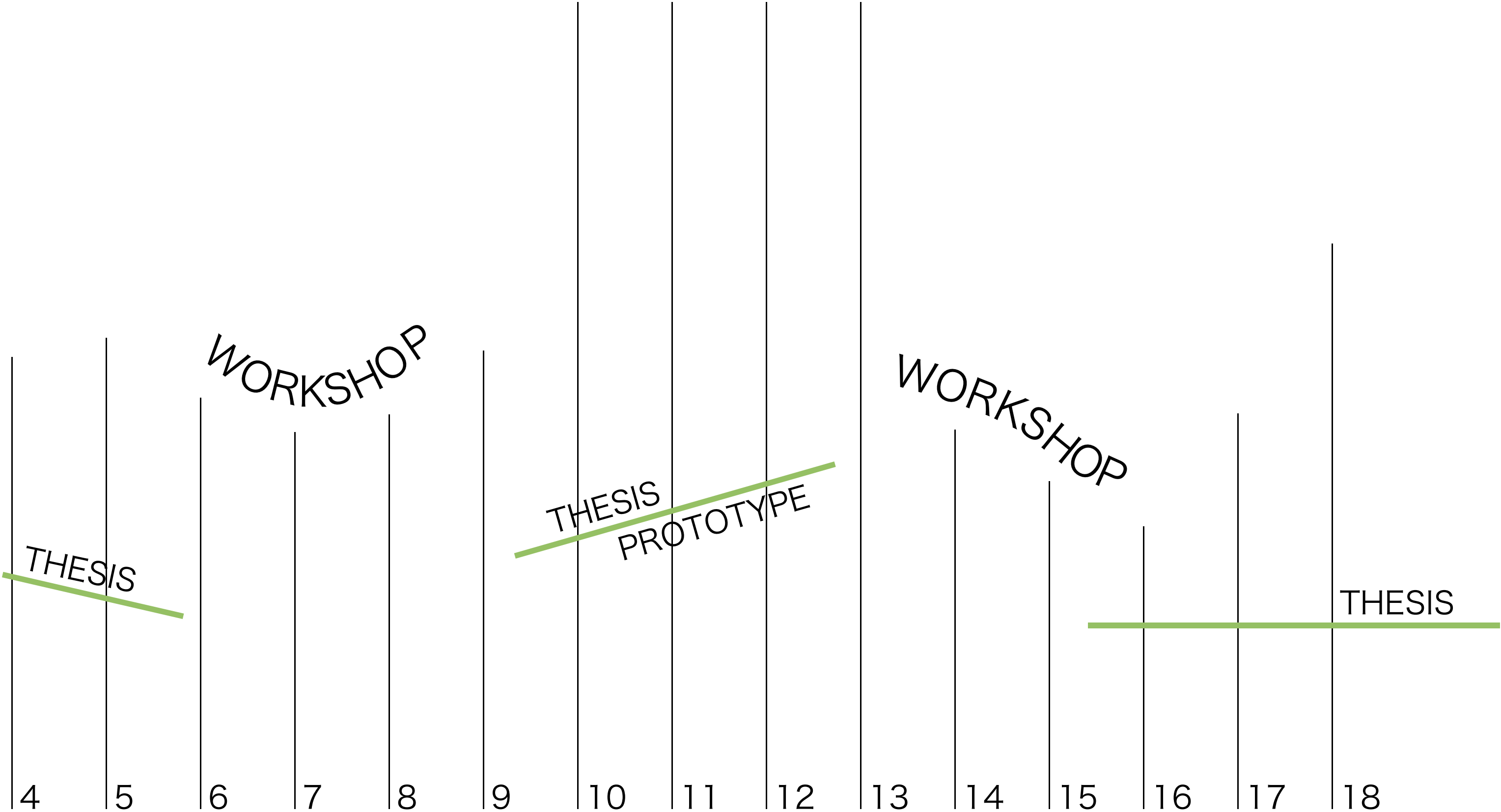
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Figs. 10, 11, 12, and 13
Sketches and Story-Telling
Digital Brush Tool

Description of Process

Timeline

This timeline consists of individual work and co-design workshops with the stakeholders, in contrast with University-led tutoring sessions and class project presentations. The timeline encompasses weeks 4 to 18, 2024. It is the application phase of Gray’s methods into workshops.



Description of Process

Context

Children with autism may be influenced by their diagnosis throughout their upbringing. Discovering how one is perceived in society and reacting to the labels pushed from outside can be overwhelming and exhausting. Indirectly, this exhaustion is reflected in that child's family. This absolutely does not mean that their life quality and complexity of experiences is minimized by the diagnosis.

Siblings of children diagnosed with autism are suspected of having trouble with emotional regulation due to unbalanced attention from grown-ups, yet this theory does not apply consistently. In this particular case study we address the relationship between two siblings, one of which is diagnosed with autism. Both of them are very creative and based on their demand we decided to start working on a graphic novel together.

Co-Designers

Nahuel is 10 years old and diagnosed with autism. He is tremendously talented at writing stories. His short stories usually revolve around a misfit protagonist. Often he depicts the main character as a supernatural creature or an animal.

Ayelen is 5 years old. Her favorite animal is the cheetah. She loves drawing and painting. Some of her drawings are finalized as abstract-looking colorful imagery.

Vic is an old-school rapper from Gothenburg and the father of these two children. He is well documented in terms of his son's diagnosis, but also critical of over-fixating on autism studies. He relates to being seen as different growing up, therefore he is cautious of how that feeling may affect his children.

Collaborator

Ari Puguh has been my project collaborator for the first half of this academic year. He is a MFA Design department student at HDK-Valand, from Gothenburg University. He has previously developed several projects in regard to children and childhood.

Our collaboration revolves around encapsulating a round design attitude. We researched shared topics in order to understand them more deeply by discussing and exchanging thoughts.

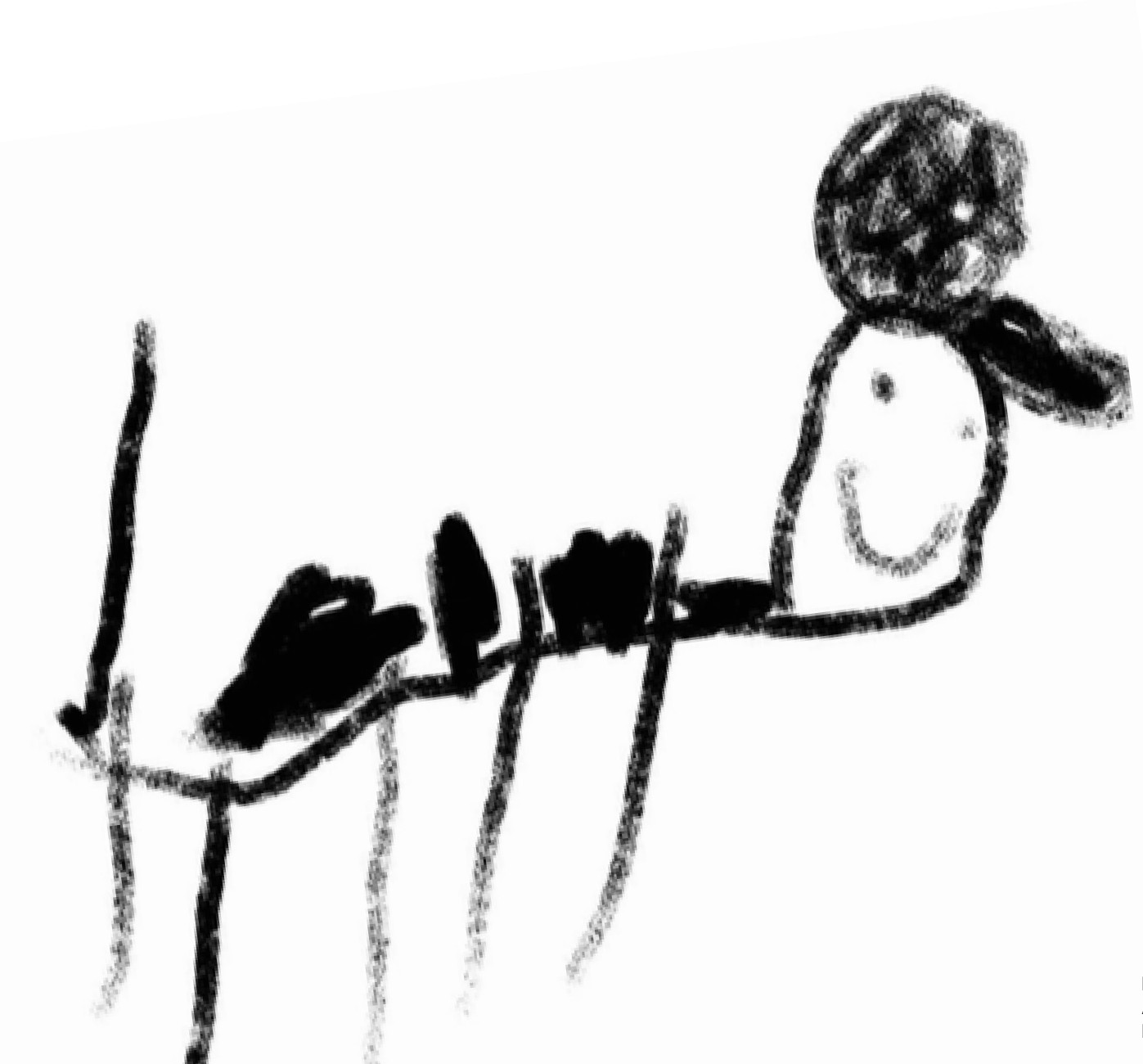


Fig. 14
Ayelen's Drawing
Digital Drawing



Fig. 15
Nahuel's Drawing
Digital Drawing

Fig. 16
Ayelen's Drawing
Coloring Book

Description of Process

Materialization

Fimo Figurines

The fimo figurines have been used in the first workshops to quickly replicate characters described by the children. There were also pre-made characters to see how the siblings relate to those figurines. It seems they have ignored the pre-made figurines, but on the other hand, have had strong reactions to those that depicted their own ideas.

The fimo plasteline is harder than usual plasteline. When Ayelen tried to make a cheetah she became annoyed at how difficult it is to model with fimo. Vic helped her calm her from frustration and afterwards I assisted her to make a cheetah.

Terrariums

The terrariums have been used to figure if the two children base their creativity in imagination or in reality. Nahuel has refused to join the task of building terrariums with us, but based on the supernatural scenarios that he invents, I assume that his creativity is imaginary-based or a mix between the two.

Ayelen and I went to collect sticks and leaves for the terrariums. When we came back and built them, Ayelen said that she replicated the park we have just been to minutes ago. That, together with the cheetah fimo figurine makes me believe that her imagination is rather reality-based.

Portal

The portal in cause, formerly under the name of *Reversed Cinema*, is an artifact from the story written in the Manuscript section. I have materialized the portal to enhance the immersion that children may experience following the story. This installation allows them to pretend-play imagining parts of the story.

Drawings

The drawings were made using various types of style and color combinations. This way I can observe how Nahuel and Ayelen react to each drawing and what attracts them most. Some drawings are drawn in sequences to reflect continuity, while other drawings present the environments and characters in individual illustrations.

Manuscript

The manuscript aims to bridge the creativity behind both of these children in a story-line that they can immediately relate to. I have introduced all characters and environments shaped together with Nahuel and Ayelen. Aside from that, I have created an antagonist that contrasts their love for animals.

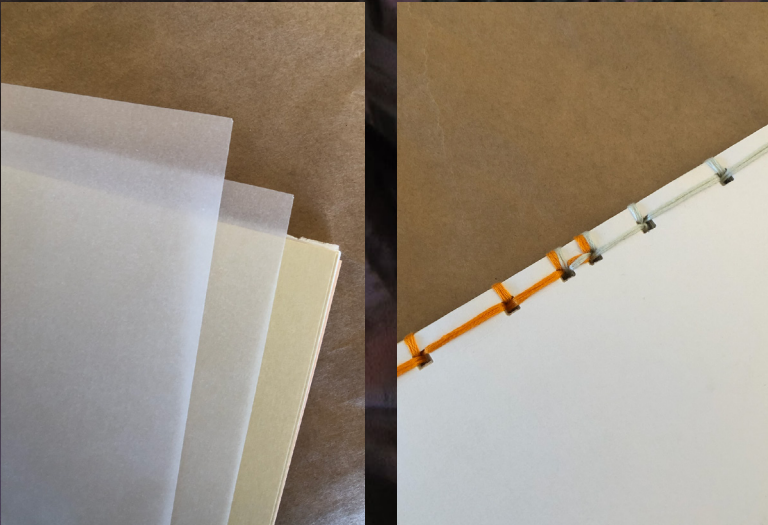
Book Pages

Based on children's reactions and editing I re-formulated the contents and learnings of this case study into a layered display of the manuscript. I used semi-transparent papers to overlay the story-line with the children's additions and corrections. Beyond these two levels of materialized collaboration, there is a third layer. The third layer consists of observations made throughout our collaboration, which I hope, brings a sense of timelessness to this book.

This timelessness appears through the fact that the same siblings can read their story getting new impressions over time.

Book Binding

The binding is just a small detail that resembles the creative collaboration of the two siblings. The bright orange colored thread symbolizes Nahuel, while the blending-in faded blue is Ayelen. Both threads meet in the center of the book binding.



Left Side
Figs. 17 and 18
Book Binding

Background and Right Side
Figs. 19, 20, 21, and 22
Artifacts from Workshops
Fimo Figurines
Terrariums

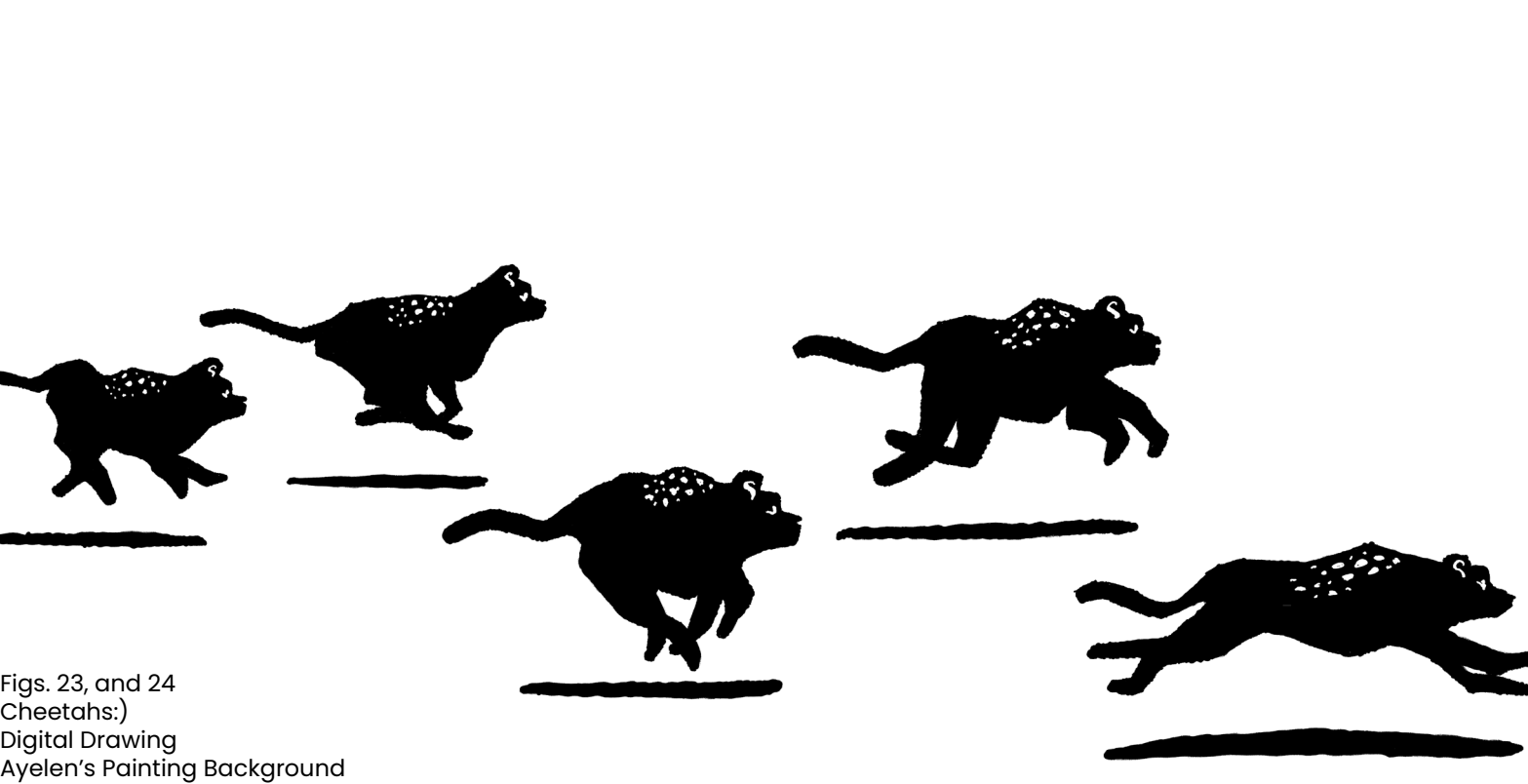


Description of Process

Critical Evaluation

The project starts off with a philosophical anchor that suggests a specific type of design attitude based on design theory and ethics. Yet once the literature gets the opportunity to be applied, the terms become a lot less strict. Learnings regarding autism in children and co-designing with children are applied rather intuitively throughout the workshops, trying to keep the pace with the children. The workshops allow the children to be creative quite freely, with a general structure or motif for each workshop. Dividing the theory in framework bases helped us explore different parts of story-telling and formulate activities around them. Supporting workshop motifs with materialized elements connects the imagination to our reality and motivate children to build on top of our previous discoveries.

The materializations are not the direct outcomes of our collaboration, but rather tools to support our explorations. Means of design have been used for creating these artifacts, yet I would rather say that the methods come first. These methods have not been strictly following the design theory, but have been adapted to the circumstances.



Figs. 23, and 24
Cheetahs:)
Digital Drawing
Ayelen's Painting Background



Description of Process

Sibling Relationship

On the line of *family systems theory*, we can expand an elaborate view into the multitude of systems that influence sibling relationships, both directly and indirectly.^[27] But within this project, I concentrate on one of the four subsystems that Minuchin enumerates, that being the *child-to-child subsystem*.^[28] The failure to distinguish between demands and stressors in disability research perpetuates the notion that ‘a family with a child with a disability is a family with a disability’, yet high demands do not inevitably equate to greater stress and psychopathological consequences.^[29] Demands may be higher in families where a child has a disability, but it does not support the premise of greater risk of maladjustment.^[30]

The father presented to me the main demand of their children, that being: individual time spent with him for the sake of undivided attention, as the two children rarely invest themselves in self-initiated common activities. Of course, the age gap and the lack of likeness in hobbies play their role in this sibling dynamic.

As Bachraz and Grace mention, following Greene and Hill: ‘Children are viewed as active agents in the construction of their social worlds and the emphasis is on child-related processes rather than child-related outcomes’, and ‘[the sibling relationship] is an entity of itself, independent of the individuals who create it’.^[31;32] Results of studies on the impact that the diagnosis of one sibling may have on the psychosocial and emotional adjustment of the other sibling have been inconsistent. Some report poor adjustment, higher rates of depression, and poor social competence for siblings of children with autism,^[34;35] other studies report the opposite, well-adjusted, with positive self-concepts, and good social competence.^[35] The inconsistencies of these reports may be often influenced by the different types of measures used, with parent reports being of a greater number and often depicting more negatively than self-reports.^[36]

In this project I received indirect depictions of the children’s relationship from their father. His input is of great use in observing their relationship and formulating strategies for workshop layouts, yet the most genuine type of description for the dynamics between the two siblings would be if it came directly from them. I further articulate throughout this paper, his role within the co-design process.

Therefore, I involved the two children in common creative activities that would generate more motivation for collaboration between them. I mostly managed to interact with the children individually and that led to them opening up about some of their interests, such as favorite video games and favorite animals. They also shared stories and made drawings, yet only separately while participating to the first two workshops at the same time, and they have shown no interest in what the other sibling was doing. It would be highly cherishable to see what comes out of their creative collaboration.

^[27]Turnbull, A. & Turnbull, R. (2001) Families, Professionals and Exceptionality: collaborating for empowerment, 4th edn. Upper Saddle River: Prentice Hall

^[28]Minuchin, P. (1985) Families and Individual Development: provocations from the field of family therapy, *Child Development*, 56(2), 289–302. <http://dx.doi.org/10.2307/1129720>

^[29]Glidden, L.M. (1993) What We Do Not Know about Families with Children Who Have Developmental Disabilities: questionnaire on resources and stress as a case study, *American Journal on Mental Retardation*, 97(5), 481– 495

^[30]Lazarus, R.S. & Folkman, S. (1984) *Stress, Appraisal and Coping*. New York: Springer

^[31]Bachraz, & Grace, R. (2009). Creating a different kind of normal : parent and child perspectives on sibling relationships when one child in the family has autism spectrum disorder. *Contemporary Issues in Early Childhood*, 10(4), 317–330. <https://doi.org/10.2304/ciec.2009.10.4.317>

^[32]Greene, S. & Hill, M. (2005) Researching Children’s Experience: methods and methodological issues, in S. Greene & D. Hogan (Eds) *Researching Children’s Experience: approaches and methods*, 1–21. London: Sage

^[33]Bagenholm, A., & Gillberg, C. (1991). Psychosocial effects on siblings of children with autism and mental retardation: A population based study. *Journal of Mental Deficiency Research*, 35, 291–307

^[34]Gold, N. (1993). Depression and social adjustment in siblings of boys with autism. *Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders*, 23, 147–163

^[35]Ferrari, M. (1984). Chronic illness: Psychosocial effects of siblings. *Journal of Child Psychology and Psychiatry*, 25, 459–476

^[36]Lobato, D., Barbour, L., Hall, L. J., & Miller, C. T. (1987). Psychosocial characteristics of handicapped and nonhandicapped

The title *Common Grounds* depicts our ambi- tions throughout the creative process, but also the relationship between Nahuel and Ayelen, as siblings, friends, and collaborators. It also resembles the res- olution of the story I have written below, since the fi- nale quite literally suggests a fusion of worlds.

What you will read in the next few pages is a side-by-side narrative and explanation of addi- tion of certain elements to the story and where they come from. I invite Vic to adapt the narrative voice to what he knows would best fit his children’s liking, for the sake of motivating them to be focused and immersed. In a previous meeting he let me listen to a few recordings of Ayelen’s cheerful and sensitive songs about love. It would be more than wonderful to implement some of those songs in the story as well, since they very genuinely reflect her artistic side. Changes in the story are, of course, more than wel- come, since the story is definitely a work in progress that should represent our collaboration as a group of creative people, trying to merge our talents as best as we can.

Exposition

The two main characters are being in- troduced, Ayelen and Nahuel. Ayelen is ap- plying the finishing touch to a gorgeous and lively pencil drawing of a Cheetah. Mean- while, sounds of knocking turtle-shells and spinning golden coins can be heard in the background. Those sound effects come from the video games that Nahuel has been playing most of the evening. His eyes look tired and ready to close at any point now. Nahuel lets go of a deep and contagious yawn that spreads over to his sister. The two of them are ready to call it a day. They go through the right- before-sleep routine, brushing their teeth, turning off the lights, and resting their heads onto the soft pillows. God natt!

Ayelen’s bedroom fades blurrily into foggy shades of green and orange. Slowly, notes of pink appear into the picture and soon the environment sharpens, taking the form of an exotic forest. She wakes up fac- ing two large and glossy graphite-like eyes. It appears to be a young cheetah! But before Ayelen reaches to pet it, the cheetah rapidly flees. The cheetah seems quite agitated as it leads the way to what could possibly be the source of its distress.

In one of the workshops Ayelen and I have been collecting sticks from the park to make small terrariums that resemble environments. My intention with this particular task was to see if Ayelen would build an imaginary-based or reality-based envi- ronment. She said that the terrariums represent the park we have just collected the sticks from, yet she referred to it as “forest”. Therefore I introduced this reality-based creative task as an element within the story. After that task she started painting with very warm colors, so I thought it would be nice to blend the previously mentioned environment-building task with her painting that she decided on doing herself. That is why the forest in the story has shades of or- ange and pink.



In the meantime, Nahuel sprints around cubes half his height and jumps through green pipes with openings that measure wide enough for him to simply fall through. He is chasing a shadow-like flying creature, or even spir- it. It is extremely difficult to make sure of this being’s nature, since it is so quick to fly away from Nahuel’s reach.

In the desparate chase to catch the living shadow, Nahuel jumps into any green pipe only to follow the creature. He feels incredibly motivated to figure at least who or what it is. The boy jumps into one last pipe before finding himself in a room full of float- ing tubular pieces of fabric, each emanating different colorful auras from top and be- neath its extremities. The shadow shows it- self enthusiastically, bridging a wide smile from one side to the other of its face. It has huge yellow eyes, no lower body, and thin arms that end in pointy claws. It looks ter- ribly horrifying.

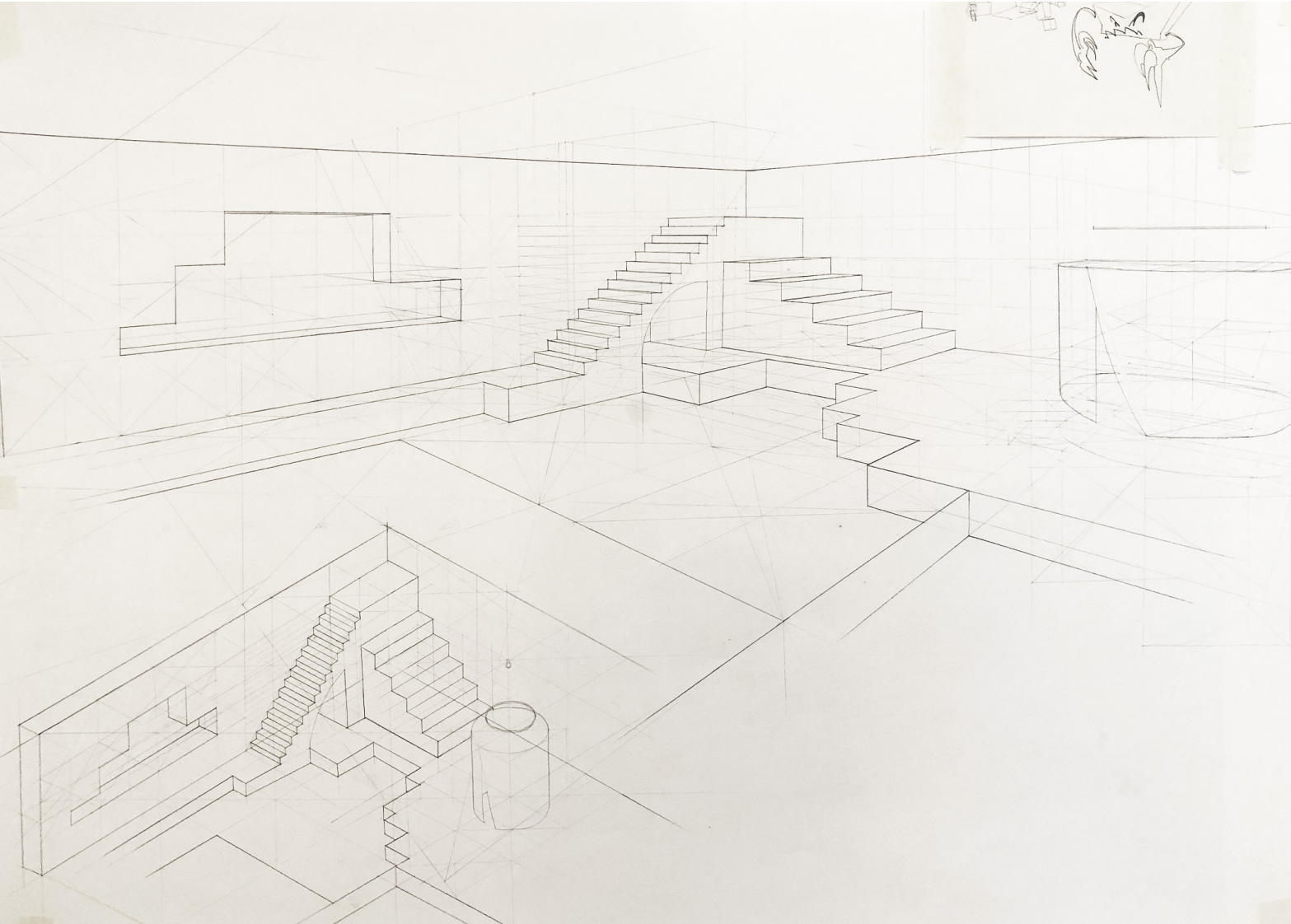
- What are these things, you Black Nightmare?!

Nahuel has explained to before that the char- acter *Black Nightmare* is mystical and can hardly be seen unless he wants to. I tried to wrap my mind around what sort of powers he could have to support the concept. I came to the conclusion that he cannot only fly at high speed or hide in shadows, but also teleport and create portal gates at his will.

Since Nahuel has shared with us his passion for video games, I believe it is more than relevant to implement it into the story somehow. I think having it displayed as his dreamland environment would be appropriate and also would bring a high con- trast aesthetic touch to the graphic novel. Personal- ly, coming back to rendering a technical drawing by hand, as I used to do about 6 years ago has brought lovely memories and made me grow even fonder to the Common Grounds story. Just as the title reflects, the story is about all of us that participate in this proj- ect, so I find it awesome be able to show some of my skills that I believe represent me creatively.

Left Page
Fig. 25
Ayelen’s Forest
Acrylic Paint on Paper

Fig. 26
Video Game Dreamland
Pre-Workshop Version
Technical Drawing
0.7mm Pencil on Paper

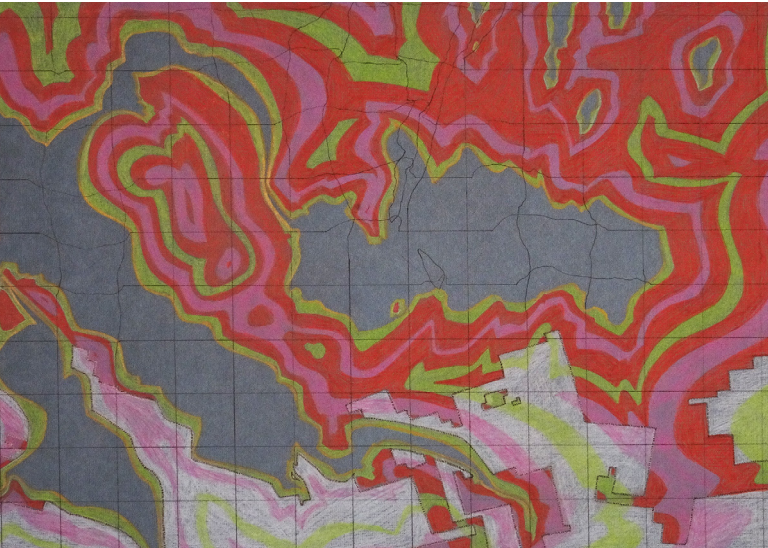


Manuscript

Rising Action

The ‘Black Nightmare’, as Nahuel just named it, spreads its long arm and grips the floating fabric, ripping a crevice into its outer layer. A shiny aura spurs out of it. The Black Nightmare invites the boy to take a peak in, what he sees through the opening is a bird-view that depicts a disaster! The vision of an increasingly annexed body of nature by a white disease spreading over. As the boy is overwhelmed by the image of a forest-killing whiteness, all of a sudden a loud growl shakes the floor. Rapid steps can be heard from the distance, quickly reaching closer. Nahuel looks behind only to be scared out of his boots by a monstrous three-headed beast. As frightened as he is, the boy jumps into the magical floating gate.

Nahuel screams his lungs out as he’s falling directly from the sky. This experience overwhelms him entirely, but luckily a dense bush absorbs the impact! When he manages to escape from the tangled branches of the bush, the boy finds himself under the ground, in a sort of artificial cave, or rather a bunker. There he finally meets his sister, Ayelen. She explains to him that the forest is being abducted by an army of painters that cover the nature with plain white. Nahuel remembers what he saw earlier, before jumping into the portal gate. The whiteness spread over the forest was from the painters all along. It is not a natural phenomenon, but a man-made plan of exploitation. In the meantime, Ayelen was trying to help her new friend, Cheetah, and the animals of the forest to hide from the painters. They were hoping that this way they could save enough time to think of a plan to save the forest.



Here I introduce the antagonist of the story and what I would call a decoy or fake antagonist. The real antagonist is a mass of painters that paint over the forest with white only, slowly colonizing the nature. Nahuel and Ayelen have been vocal about their love for nature and animals, so I imagine that based on this common love. The obvious way to go about it would be to contour an antagonist that affects the harmony of nature negatively. I took inspiration from Michael Ende’s novel ‘Momo’, where the antagonist is vaguely human and showing a severe lack of personality and feelings.^[37] We also get the first glimpse of The *Three-Headed Dog*, a decoy antagonist that later shows it actually cares about others and what bothers him the most is when children and animals are put in danger by people with bad will. He is also one of the characters created by Nahuel.

Finally the protagonists meet again, this time in Ayelen’s dreamland instead of real life. Ayelen’s love and care for animals is depicted quite directly as she tries to hide them from the painters. Cheetah becomes a sort of kin to Ayelen. This character is based on the girl’s affinity for cheetahs. Due to how often she brought it up throughout one of the workshops, when we talked about her favorite animals and when we tried to make one out of fimo clay.

Fig. 27
Forest Map
Pencil and Fine Liner on Colored Paper

^[37]Ende, M. (1973). Puffin Books, translated by Brownjohn, J. M., 7, 69–90



Fig. 28
Three-Headed Dog
Comic Strip Painting
Water Color on Paper

Climax

The Ground starts shaking, but before assuming that it is an earthquake, a familiar and spine-shivering rumble can be heard from above the ground surface.

- Growl!!!

At the sight of the terrifying three-headed beast, the painters drop their jaws and brushes also. For those that are far into the distance, the echoing roar is more than enough of a good reason to immediately start running the opposite way. All painters flee, and scream, and cry in terror, some of them even peed their overalls.

Falling Action

The children and the animals peak out their heads to see how the forest is entirely emptied of painters, leaving only the brushes and buckets of white paint behind them. They are also afraid of the three-headed creature, except Ayelen and Nahuel, who approach it slowly.

- Thank you so much for saving my friends and the forest! What is your name? wonders Ayelen.
- I am The Three-Headed Dog.
- Thank you, Three-Headed Dog!
- Three Headed-Dog, could I please ask you why were you chasing me before we teleported to the forest? asks Nahuel.
- I saw you trying to catch my dear brother, Black Nightmare, were you not? asks the Three-Headed Dog.
- I understand. I wasn’t meaning to harm him. We were just playing, then he opened a portal gate and now we are all here... What is here actually? says Nahuel.

Only as far in the story as we are right now we can see the characters have a conversation where the main questions arise to the surface. The plot is becoming clearer, preparing the narrative for a soft resolution. The reader would experience a portion of plot-twist and intensity relief after all the chasing and loud growling.



Fig. 29
Colors, Shapes, and Silhouettes
Colored Markers on Paper

- We are in Ayelen's dreamland! explains Black Nightmare, stretching his wide smile, and, of course, before we were in Nahuel's dreamland. I have the power to teleport myself and others through people's dreams at my own will.

- Black Nightmare, what's going to happen to the forest now that the painters are gone? The whiteness is still covering a good part of the nature. asks Ayelen concerned about his new friends.

- Wait a minute! shouts Nahuel as he seems to have an idea. You just said you can teleport people to other dreamlands, right? Can't you simply connect two dreamlands all together?

- I never thought of doing that before! Hmm... I guess I could?

- Could you, please, teleport my dreamland into the parts of the forest that are covered with white paint?

- Yes! Why not?! Let's give it a shot!

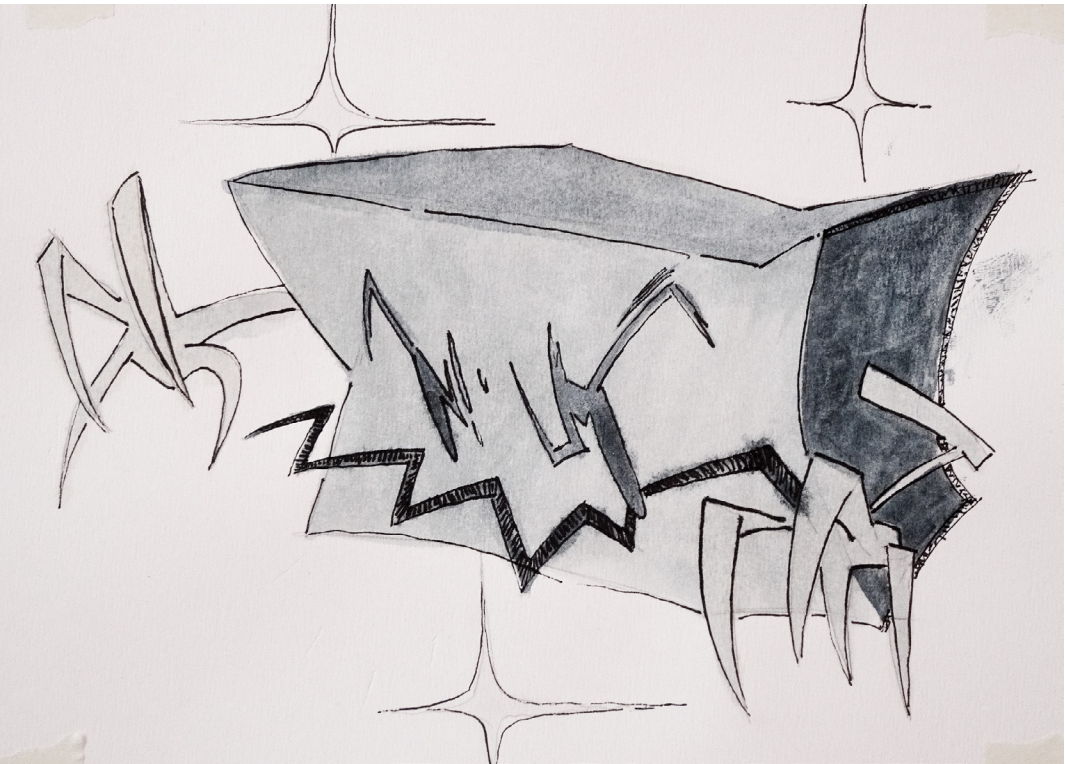
I hope it is visible how familiarity plays an important role in the structure of this story. Familiarity keeps the children focused and immersed in the narrative. One way to implement it is to attach the children themselves to the story-line as protagonists. Another way is to bring certain elements in their real-life environment, not only in the story.

Resolution

The Black Nightmare merges the two dreamlands into one seamless world of nature and video games, fostering all sorts of play opportunities. He and his brother, The Three-Headed Dog are invited by the children and the animals to live together on their new common grounds, where love and friendship are fundamental values for everyone.

I suggest this type of ending for the purpose of creating a metaphor that supports the idea of collaboration and 'common grounds'. It can be read as a means of sharing and promoting the idea that together with friends and family, we are more content and happy in life. I hope this resolution brings back to surface that the story is in fact very much about the two siblings, created with ideas coming from them.

Fig. 30
Black Nightmare
Water Color & Fine Liner on Paper



The Video Game Dreamland Technical Drawing

I have rendered a technical drawing, that through its geometrical style, depicts my interpretation of a partially generic video game environment. Within the scenery of this drawing can be seen a tubular floating entity – the portal that The Black Nightmare spawns to travel through people’s dreamlands. I have left the drawing uncolored, hoping that the two children would naturally feel the urge to fill in the blanks. Which in fact did happen, Ayelen took an assertive stance towards her brother, guiding him to color the sky blue. Stepping away for just a moment from analysing the drawing strictly visually as a result, and rather have eyes from the process behind it, one can argue that the moment of direct and adjacent collaboration between the two marks a common space achieved in practice. Ayelen’s assertiveness cannot be seen outside of her sister role. At the same time, it can also be attributed to Turnbull’s and Turnbull’s family systems or one of Minuchin’s four subsystems, precisely the child-to-child subsystem.^[27;28] From my perspective, I can see that Ayelen takes a role that only she can within our team. Her sisterly assertiveness does not suffer imbalance from any sort of power dynamic. In response to that, Nahuel trustingly follows his sister’s lead. The two siblings own their interaction covering up the line-work drawing in scribbles. The blue sky is evident, yet the rest of the rendering is covered in black without regard of contour, making it unreachable for me to decipher at first glance. In a moment like this I get the opportunity to choose between asking for a direct explanation from the children, or let myself reinterpret the piece as it is in its current state. I chose to do the latter, because I was willing to step in as a collaborator once again, allocating the new form of the drawing as a keyframe within the story-line we have been developing together as a group. Therefore, the drawing’s making depicts the process-based attributes of a child-centered case study. While, from a productivist point of view, the visual presence of the drawing’s evolution resembles the formulation of a story element.

^[27]Turnbull, A. & Turnbull, R. (2001) Families, Professionals and Exceptionality: collaborating for empowerment, 4th edn. Upper Saddle River: Prentice Hall

^[28]Minuchin, P. (1985) Families and Individual Development: provocations from the field of family therapy, Child Development, 56(2), 289–302. <http://dx.doi.org/10.2307/1129720>



Fig. 31
Story-Telling Workshop Drawing
Markers on Paper

Figs. 32 and 33
Co-Drawing Method

The Forest Map

Just like the previously mentioned drawing portrays a piece of my creative identity in the shape of skill and personal interest to technical drawing and geometry, the map also brings forward my passion for cartography and geography that I have been nurturing in the past few years. I assume that I took the decision to draw the forest in the form of a map, instead of a landscape or something else of the sort, because of my current dive into political geography and history of political borders. These aesthetic formulations are affected by my own affiliation with the various styles of drawing and painting. I believe it is relevant, if not crucial, to make my own input just as visible instead of striving for complete transparency. I am as well an active member in this group and my identity, however illustrated best, might as well be surfaced for a round representation of our group identity. Yet, since group decisions must flourish most in this project, the children’s reactions to my choice of style and colors is a fundamental aspect to our collaboration.

I made the forest drawing as a map to show a large scale story element. Using this wide lens approach, the reader can understand that the villains of the story generate an immense damage to this world and its inhabitants. The villains in cause are a group of painters. They use white paint to cover large portions of the forest and claim them as their own territories. They erase life and history from the spots that are now surrounded by straight-lined borders. Evidently, this is a rendering of political conflicts, inspired by familiar real-life events, into a fictional realm. My argument supporting such a decision would be the timelessness attribute of such a story. I believe that a story for children that does not allow coming back while growing up, is a story that rather supports aetionormativistic prospects.^[6] Talking about timelessness, a great source of inspiration for building the antagonist(s) for this story has been Momo, by Michael Ende.^[37] More precisely, I was inspired by the grey men that induce time-related anxiety and paranoia into the minds of civil-

^[6]Barad, K. (2007), Meeting the Universe Halfway: Quantum Physics and the Entanglement of Matter and Meaning. Duke University Press

^[37]Ende, M. (1973). Puffin Books, translated by Brownjohn, J. M., 7, 69–90

^[19]Frith, U. (1972) Cognitive mechanisms in autism: Experiments with color and tone sequence production. Journal of Autism and Childhood Schizophrenia, 2, 160–173

^[20]Scott, F., & Baron-Cohen, S. (1996). Imagining real and unreal things: Evidence of a dissociation in autism. Journal of Cognitive Neuroscience, 8, 400–411

ians, making them change their behaviours and interact with each other less often. The painters adopt to their personality a similar kind of facelessness and anonymity, by being a group with one particular and stream-lined task, claiming territory by simply painting over it with white. In both cases, the Common Grounds narrative, and Momo, these antagonists wear an obvious political layer. The political attributes of these antagonists may not be as obvious to children if we would ask them to formulate it with the ‘appropriate’ political terminology. Yet the concepts as graspable, and the villains’ intentions can easily be read through and interpreted by children (including neurodivergent children) just as well as grown ups.

The colors for this map come from a previous painting of Ayelen’s, while the concept of forest comes from the small terrariums we have built together. I have combined the outcomes from both tasks to mix Ayelen’s contour-giving reality-based imagination with her practical output of abstract painting.^[19;20] I do not think I was clear enough to her in matter of this fusion of outcomes, but my intentions were anyway rather concentrated on the visual stimuli appeal through reference to possibly preferred colors. She may or may not like this color combination over other color combinations. Either way, neither her or Nahuel have drawn or commented this drawing in particular, neither have they reacted noticeably to it while their father and I told them the story-line behind the drawings. I also had the impression that it may have some appeal to them simply as a colorful abstract drawing, yet I cannot confirm that either. The map shows little process-based aspects, while rather being a child-centered product as it is, based on aforementioned arguments.

Page 26
Fig. 27
Forest Map
Pencil and Fine Liner on Colored Paper

Description of Results

The Comic Style Water Color Painting

This painting encapsulates a sequential visualization of a fictional event. The top part of the painting consists of the dramatic entrance of a character mentioned by Nahuel in one of the first workshops – The Three-Headed Dog. The Three-Headed Dog appears to the surprise of the antagonists – the painters – who drop their tools and run away in fear of the beast. After the painters are scared away, children gain confidence to reach out of their hiding spot and presumably approach The Three-Headed Dog. The two kids depicted in the painting are contoured after the cartoonish likeness of Ayelen and Nahuel. This decision was taken in order to stimulate the interest of the two siblings based on attributes of familiarity. Supposedly, if it has been so far fruitful to repeatedly reference the children’s creations and interests in order to maintain them focused and motivated, I have considered trying to take this idea further, bringing them into the story. This format has been inspired by Carol Gray’s Comic Strip Conversations, a method through which Gray distances the stakeholders from the physicality of events, by simulating them in the form of comic strips.^[23] These comic strips contain conversations and situations where the stakeholders are rendered within the frames, in order for them to more easily imagine how they would respond or react without the pressure of actually being part of those certain events. Visualization of such events maintain the stakeholders’ focus better than usual conversations that start with asking ‘what if’,.They stimulate another sense and aid imagination. The painting I made shows two children obtaining courage to start a dialogue with the scary beast, whom until this moment, almost every character from this universe has seemed to be terrified of. Why so much stress upon the factor of fear attached to The Three-Headed Dog? Why the sudden change in children’s perspective upon this seemingly flat character? When Nahuel first shared with me the concept of The Three-Headed Dog, he has explained to me that the beast only attacks people that hurt animals, but not *animal-loving children*. That does not support enough the sudden confidence of the two child characters to approach The Three-Headed Dog. Vic has shown me pictures of Nahuel petting dogs that he just met minutes before the photos have been shot. He told me that his son has a good relationship with animals and often reaches to pet them without fear. These new informations about Nahuel’s

relationship with animals has only motivated me to somehow add it to the story-line. Therefore, as it can be seen in the bottom-right corner, Nahuel takes Ayelen’s hand and together they exit the hiding spot. The cartoonish bat only suggests that this action is either unmeasured or brave from its point of view, or rather enhances the reader’s point of view.

On the other hand, even with the confirmation from the children that this comic strip is genuine to the story and they appreciate the looks of it, it has its own short-comings. The siblings have not drawn at all over this comic strip, but only next to it. They voiced that the painting is beautiful as it is, which may be great to hear in regard of trying to deliver a proper understanding of their imagination in visual format interpretation, but at the same time it inhibited their urge to add anything to it visually. No coloring, no scribbles, no text. Makes me ask myself if it is even as relevant to the project as other examples, since it does little in regard of the process-based dogma when shown in this form. Although, Ayelen has added to the story indirectly through this comic strip, as she pointed out that she wants the moustache-man painter to become an important character into this story, preferably the painters’ leader. This has been so far the first and only direct editing in regard to the narrative coming from Ayelen. I believe it is some sort of proof that the Common Grounds methodology provides children the opportunity to shift roles within the creative process (audience, actor, scriptwriter, artist, and editor). Therefore, their understanding of narrative coagulates.^[25]

Shapes, Colors, and Sillhuetes

These sequential marker drawings have also been labelled as beautiful yet untouchable by the two children. I was curious in regard to stronger colors and abstractified impressionism. The children have liked the drawings, but have not had the urge to add elements through sketching or demand changes. Both in this case and the previously mentioned comic strip with more subtle colors, the question of continuing collaboration has appeared to me. To be clear, the drawings reference output creative information coming from the two siblings, yet it seems to have reached some sort of milestone in this shape. In such situations I am inclining towards judging the result as a product piece. It has reached a point in its form-giving process where I could take a moment to analyse the potential reasons behind being judged as ‘good’ by my collaborators. Is it the style? Maybe the colors or the color combination? Could it be just its atmosphere? This collection of drawings is ambiguously ‘right’ within a process-based project. At the same time, surfacing the aspect of trust in a collaboration, I could simply accept that, in some way or another, I understood what my collaborators meant when they shared their ideas with me, and properly appropriated that through my own artistic interpretation. Taking a few steps away from my analytical self, I have the freedom the take the children’s response as it is, just as I would do with an adult. It may sound as I am overly-simplifying the case after this whole obsessively analytical journey, yet if the children would have not given these few drawings their ‘thumbs up’, they would have probably just drawn over them already.

Fig. 34
Ayelen, her drawing, and her candy
Story-Telling Workshop
Co-Drawing



^[23]Gray, C. (1994) Comic strip conversations: illustrated interactions with students with autism and related disorders

^[25]Marshall, P., Rogers, Y., Scaife, M. (2002). Puppet: a virtual environment for children to act and direct interactive narratives. In:Proceedings of the Second Workshop on Narrative and Interactive Learning Environ.

Description of Results

Drawing Collage

This drawing collage was completely blank when stuck onto the wall, next to papers that I have already drawn on. To make the empty papers more appealing I have overlapped a few differently textured papers, some colored, and a few semi-transparent ones as well. I have drawn alongside Ayelen. I drew a red-contoured cartoonish painter character, while Ayelen scribbled on top of the white base paper. She used pink and blue markers, similar colors to the papers I priorly taped onto the white base paper. I drew yet another larger painter, and in the meantime, Vic felt the urge to show me his tagging skills. He wrote ‘Ay’ on top (short for Ayelen), and ‘Nahuel’ right below it. The transparent paper he tagged on was taped in a different spot, but I thought it would fit in a new position, layered over Ayelen’s pink scribbles. I was explaining before the importance of bringing skills and personal interests to the core of our collaboration in order to achieve a genuine group identity.

When the family was done drawing, the papers were still half empty. Days later, I had another look at it and I thought to myself to try and finish it, act as if someone gave me a drawing to add to. I drew instinctively, not much thought was behind each decision more than one can see at first glance. It seems my approach for this case is reversed. I was put in the position to choose between drawing over and drawing besides. If anything, I felt more confident drawing over my own sketches. I played with layering and texturing. Currently, the collage looks somewhat like a moodboard. It has no linearity or order, vaguely relating to the motif of the antagonist and its effects upon the environment and the animals. My process was apparently against resultivism, claiming to be far from a product.



Bottom Left
Fig. 35
Drawing Collage
Story-Telling Workshop
Co-Drawing Method
Markers on Paper

Top Left
Fig. 36
Vic’s Tag
Story-Telling Workshop
Co-Drawing Method
Blue Marker on Paper

Bottom Center
Fig. 37
Drawing Collage
Post-Workshop
Mixed Media



The Portal

The Reversed Cinema has been carrying several purposes. It is first of all a fictional artifact materialized to support a deeper immersion into the story for the two siblings. It is meant to be projected onto, for looking at the drawings realized for the story. It is made with consciousness of the stakeholders’ needs, especially in regard of autism. It is planned as the center piece of an immersive workshop setup. For the time being, the firstly mentioned purpose is the only activated. Because of that, from now on, I will call it just *the portal*, even if it comes to activate all of its planned purposes in the near future.

The above paragraph may seem to insinuate misfortune, but the decision to take it one step at a time with the portal is based on matter of familiarity as a mean of security for children with autism. I hesitated to present the portal in its Reversed Cinema form because it would be funneling too directly into an experience shaped by changing the environment’s appearance. The room had to be changed for assembling the setup. I decided to hit the breaks for a moment and instead prepare a workshop that may be seen as a deconstructed version of the one planned for the Reversed Cinema. This way the children can form an acquaintanceship to the installation and interact with it as they wish, without strict guidance. This resulted in a fantastic confirmation of the story-line coming from the children, as they started to pretend-play with the installation as if it was the real portal from the story. The portal has joined the intra-action space in a new and more fluid condition.^[8]



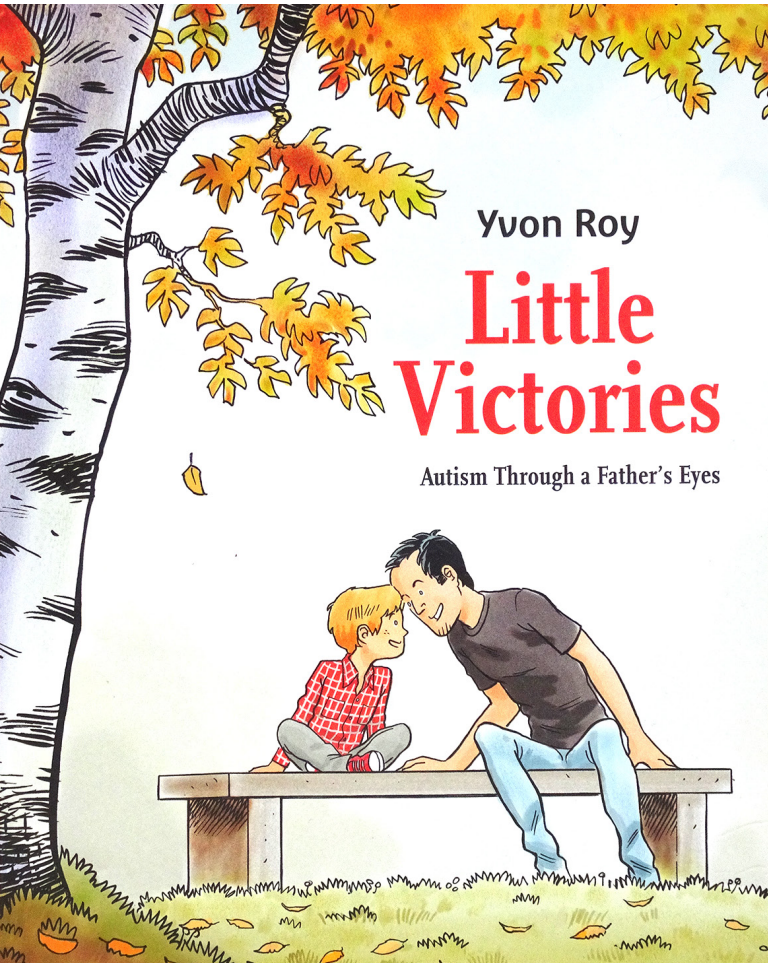
Fig. 38
Portal
Cheesecloth Fabric

^[8]Lenz Taguchi, H. (2010). Going beyond the theory/practice divide in early childhood education: Intro- ducing an intra-active pedagogy. Abingdon: Routledge

Little Victories

Autism still isn't well understood. I think that by watching him, I'll know better about his particular autism than anyone else.^[38]

This line comes from Yvon Roy's *Little Victories* graphic novel which I read after the last workshop. This quote succinctly puts one of the biggest learning outcomes, looking back at the gradual shift from the strict approaches and sterile conclusions coming from the theoretical base of this project, to the intuitive and improvisational strategies that both Ari Puguh and I adopted. I did learn about autism more intensely and rapidly than ever, but at the same time I also learned about my collaborators and stakeholders. I learned about childrens' interests and their ways of expressing feelings. General or particular, the *little victories* achieved in collaboration to these children is strongly grounded in the moments of creation and conversation. This depth of insight is the reason for choosing a qualitative approach to the research question.



^[38]Roy, Y. (2021). *Little Victories: Autism Through a Father's Eyes* (Graphic Novel). Titan

Conclusion

This case study consists of a series of workshops that sequentially suggest a progression in terms of acquaintanceship and, therefore, social, but also spatial comfort. The time and space for the meetings has been chosen with respect to children's emotional needs. Generally speaking, children with autism better face familiar situations. The same condition applies in relation to people and objects (in this case, artifacts and tools).

In terms of participation, the children have suggested the creative goal that fruits from the workshops. After taking the incipient decision regarding what we produce together, Nahuel and Ayelen had consistent influence over the story-line and visual representation. The project is child-centered. The design decisions regarding the story-line level of this project is generally filtered through the impression of these two talented siblings. The decisions are either directly taken based on their opinion, or bent around their reactions and explanations coming from their father. Hence, this co-design project is placed between Hart's sixth and seventh levels of children's participation – '*adult-initiated*'.

This project has challenged Nahuel and Ayelen creatively, but also emotionally. The narrative we have built together allows them to see themselves in Common Grounds individually, but the motif behind this story-line lies in being together. The story starts off with both children doing their own thing in the same room. Later it opens up representations of inner worlds and personal passion. It involves a separation and a reunion, and it ends with an evenly unified dream-world, where differences are present, but far from being a threat to co-existing. Building an entire story and making illustration to emphasize the story that the two siblings already live, which is their own sibling relationship, proves to be an extensive, yet round and sensitive approach. I imagine this story will gain more emotional layers, such as nostalgia, at the same pace with Nahuel and Ayelen growing up and coming back to read it. The project has taken several turns, but it has consistantly been about Nahuel and Ayelen relationship. The story cannot be about Nahuel's ASD diagnosis without first being about Nahuel and his family.

Fig. 39
Little Victories Book Cover

Next Steps

From now on I can call the Common Grounds framework what it is and move onto developing the details of the book until it becomes a finished piece. But this paper suggests that the book is only the materialization that comes from applying Common Grounds methods in the context of this family in particular. If the methods would be used together with other siblings that have a hard time engaging in the same ativities at once, then the material results would be greatly different. Of course, the materializations must still stand as a metaphor for the sibling relationship in cause, but the means of production and communication would vary. This approach leads to creating anything that symbolizes a sibling relationship, while at the same time being enacted with the scope of consolidating and strenghten a relationship of the sort.

I take the opportunity to add the contents of our process to Nahuel's and Ayelen's book, in order to share it with other families that find hardship in emotional regulation and time allocation when neurodivergence is added to the equation.



Fig. 40
Exposition Drawing
Colored Pencils on Paper

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Appendix

Fig. 1 Research Mind Map Miro Board	Fig. 2 Frame Over Terrariums Materialization Workshop Digital Photography	Fig. 3 Workshop Materials	Figs. 4, 5, and 6 Portal Cheesecloth Fabric
Fig. 7 Workshop Materials Mixed Media	Background Fig. 8 Reversed Cinema Installation Cheesecloth	Fig. 9 Fimo Figurines	Figs. 10, 11, 12, and 13 Sketches and Story-Telling Digital Brush Tool
Fig. 14 Ayelen's Drawing Digital Drawing	Fig. 15 Nahuel's Drawing Digital Drawing	Fig. 16 Ayelen's Drawing Coloring Book	Left Side Figs. 17 and 18 Book Binding
Background and Right Side Figs. 19, 20, 21, and 22 Artifacts from Workshops Fimo Figurines Terrariums	Figs. 23, and 24 Cheetahs:) Digital Drawing Ayelen's Painting Background	Left Page Fig. 25 Ayelen's Forest Acrylic Paint on Paper	Fig. 26 Video Game Dreamland Pre-Workshop Version Technical Drawing 0.7mm Pencil on Paper
Fig. 27 Forest Map Pencil and Fine Liner on Colored Paper		Fig. 28 Three-Headed Dog Comic Strip Painting Water Color on Paper	Fig. 29 Colors, Shapes, and Sillhuetes Colored Markers on Paper
Fig. 30 Black Nightmare Water Color & Fine Liner on Paper		Fig. 31 Story-Telling Workshop Drawing Markers on Paper	
Figs. 32 and 33 Co-Drawing Method	Fig. 34 Ayelen, her drawing, and her candy Story-Telling Workshop Co-Drawing		Bottom Left Fig. 35 Drawing Collage Story-Telling Workshop Co-Drawing Method Markers on Paper
Top Left Fig. 36 Vic's Tag Story-Telling Workshop Co-Drawing Method Blue Marker on Paper	Bottom Center Fig. 37 Drawing Collage Post-Workshop Mixed Media	Fig. 38 Portal Cheesecloth Fabric	Fig. 39 <i>Little Victories</i> Book Cover
Fig. 40 Exposition Drawing Colored Pencils on Paper			

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